

Kristen Steffler Varona

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Senior Product Manager | Technical Product Manager | AI-Native | SaaS

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

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I lead product teams by making complexity legible fast. I assess the product, the architecture, the delivery patterns, and the blockers, then establish the structure and sequencing that moves organizations forward.

I have done this as an embedded technical product manager, 0→1 product builder, and consultant across enterprise platforms, SaaS products, ecommerce, fintech, and retail technology systems.

At Kanban Zone, I built a workflow SaaS from zero to a patented, profitable platform, owning product strategy, system architecture, and engineering delivery simultaneously. At Plexus Worldwide, I walked into a four-year stalled modernization program, established the delivery structure from scratch, and shipped the full initiative in fourteen months while absorbing an unplanned market expansion mid-stream.

I am technically fluent across the full product lifecycle. I understand APIs, system integrations, platform architecture, and delivery mechanics well enough to make informed product decisions without needing things translated for me. Currently, I am building an AI-native SaaS, using AI as an engineering partner, product intelligence layer, and operational tool.

CORE SKILLS

Product & Delivery Product Roadmaps | Stakeholder Management | Customer Insights | Backlog Management | Agile/Sprint Planning | Features, User Stories & Acceptance Criteria | Release Management | Product Discovery | A/B Testing | KPIs & Metrics | Go-to-Market

Technical APIs & System Integration | Platform Architecture | PaaS | SQL | Event-Driven Systems | CI/CD | Cloud Platforms | AI/ML Product Integration | Data Modeling | Rapid Prototyping

Tools Jira | Confluence | PostHog | Full Story | GitHub | Figma | Claude | OpenAI APIs

Domain Retail Technology | POS Systems | E-Commerce | Subscription, Payments & Reconciliation | SaaS Platforms | Enterprise Software | Regulatory Compliance

EXPERIENCE

Plexus Worldwide

Manager, (Technical Product Management)
May 2024 – July 2025

Summary:

Rescued a four-year stalled enterprise modernization program, delivering it in 14 months while absorbing a concurrent Japan market expansion mid-stream. Led seven engineers across onshore, offshore, and contract arrangements while owning the full technical product roadmap and executive stakeholder alignment.

- Led a critical-path enterprise modernization initiative through full production readiness in 14 months by establishing a cohesive technical roadmap and sequencing execution across 7 distributed engineers.
- Built and operationalized the technical backlog from zero, translating business priorities into structured epics, sequencing, and execution plans across distributed onshore/offshore engineering teams.
- Directed cross-functional alignment across product, engineering, and executive leadership, resolving competing priorities and establishing clear delivery expectations without formal authority.

- Delivered a last-minute Japan market expansion on schedule with minimal impact to the core 14-month modernization timeline. I achieved this by re-sequencing parallel workstreams and managing technical dependencies across logistics, e-commerce, and direct sales systems.
- Owned the e-commerce technical roadmap across APIs, platform capabilities, and release management, aligning delivery execution with business KPIs and operational goals.
- Improved release cadence and delivery predictability by 50%, strengthening Agile execution practices and establishing more consistent production deployment cycles.
- Managed a team of seven engineers across onshore, offshore, and contract arrangements, including performance reviews, growth planning, and hiring and termination decisions.

Kanban Zone LLC

Co-Founder, CTO & Product Architect
Jan 2017 – Oct 2023

Summary:

Co-founded and scaled a B2B SaaS workflow platform from zero to a patented, profitable product, owning every product, architecture, and engineering decision for seven years. Grew to 3,000+ users on a bootstrapped budget while maintaining a high-velocity daily deployment cadence. kanbanzone.com

- Designed and scaled a SaaS platform as a full-stack system, including system architecture, API design, and end-to-end technical product direction, serving as the de facto product and engineering leadership function.
- Led continuous product delivery over six years, operating a high-velocity release cadence while driving roadmap prioritization and cross-stream product evolution.
- Applied product telemetry (usage behavior, funnels, and retention metrics) to inform prioritization, identify friction points, and optimize activation and engagement outcomes.
- Led structured customer discovery and iterative beta programs, translating user feedback into product decisions that improved usability and market alignment.
- Directed build-vs-buy decisions, roadmap prioritization, and delivery tradeoffs across engineering execution, product quality, and timeline constraints.
- Built and led a cross-functional team of three to five distributed team members spanning UX, development, and QA, independently sourcing, interviewing, and selecting team members.
- Designed and evolved subscription and add-on monetization systems, improving conversion flows through targeted in-product mechanisms and pricing iteration.

Office Depot Latin America

Contract, Retail Systems SME (POS & Regulatory Systems)
February 2019 – February 2023

Summary:

Owned product delivery and technical maintenance for a multi-country POS platform across three retail chains in Latin America, each with distinct codebases and regulatory requirements. Ensured zero disruption to revenue-critical store operations while advising on next-generation POS integration and rollout strategy.

- Directly managed the functional and technical delivery of POS payment, tax, and compliance systems, leading the full product lifecycle from client requirements through to production rollout.
- Improved operational reliability across multi-country retail chains by managing a POS platform that integrated full-stack hardware—including cash drawers, printers, and pole displays—ensuring zero disruption to store operations during regulatory updates
- Maintained and evolved a multi-country point-of-sale platform across Office Depot, RadioShack, and Marchant brands, operating distinct regional codebases with varying regulatory and operational constraints.

- Owned hardware integration and API strategy across distributed retail POS environments, ensuring consistent interoperability across device types and store configurations.
- Delivered enhancements, defect remediation, and regulatory compliance updates across multiple retail systems while supporting migration toward a next-generation POS platform, ensuring continuity of revenue-critical store operations.
- Advised on integration architecture and rollout strategy for next-generation POS systems, bridging legacy platform constraints with modernized retail and payment capabilities across regions.

Blue Drop Solutions LLC

Technical Product Consultant | Product & Engineering Delivery
May 2011 – March 2024

Summary:

Delivered product and engineering transformation engagements for enterprise clients, including American Express, Best Western International, SkyTouch, and Blue Cross Blue Shield of Arizona. Led a full-scale agile and DevOps transformation at Best Western, restructuring the technology organization from waterfall to continuous delivery.

- Provided executive advisory to senior leadership on product strategy, delivery prioritization, and organizational operating model design across enterprise technology environments.
- Delivered enterprise transformation engagements across fintech, healthcare, hospitality, and retail clients, including American Express, Blue Cross Blue Shield of Arizona, and CSAA
- Led a full-scale technology and delivery transformation at Best Western International, restructuring teams into cross-functional delivery units and transitioning the organization from waterfall execution to continuous delivery practices.
- Introduced scaled Kanban, DevOps practices, and test automation approaches to improve delivery flow, predictability, and engineering throughput across distributed teams.

JDA Software (now Blue Yonder)

Software Engineer → Technical Lead / Architect
June 1998 – 2010

Summary:

Spent over a decade building enterprise retail platforms, including POS, replenishment, pricing, loyalty, and payment systems for major North American and Latin American retailers. Progressed from consulting engineer to technical lead and architect, including a solo performance optimization that reduced a nightly batch process from hours to minutes.

- Progressed from consulting engineer to technical lead and architect, operating across multiple enterprise systems and technologies while supporting POS, replenishment, and logistics platforms in production environments.
- Reduced pricing synchronization time from 7 hours to under 10 minutes by identifying performance bottlenecks and redesigning the central-office-to-store batch execution path for high-volume retail environments.
- Architected and led delivery for a large-scale retail replenishment platform that coordinated inventory and demand logic across distributed retail networks for Tier-1 North American retailers.
- Delivered custom point-of-sale enhancements for major North American retailers, including pricing, tax, compliance, loyalty, and payment systems, working directly with clients through requirements definition, BRDs, and production rollout support.

CURRENT PROJECTS

FlowBIZen

Product Owner & Builder

May 2026

Summary: AI-native virtual Kanban coaching tool in development that analyzes board flow metrics to surface bottlenecks, patterns, and actionable coaching insights for delivery teams. Designed for small and medium business owners currently using manual tools or Trello who need visibility into team efficiency and metrics..

- Defined target user persona and validated market opportunity based on domain expertise across seven years of Kanban platform development and enterprise agile coaching
- Designed core data model for card activity tracking, capturing movement history across columns, swimlanes, boards, and team members to support flow metric analysis and ML-based pattern detection
- Building Python-based AI agent workflows to automate coaching nudge delivery and bottleneck identification

TrailOS

Product Owner & Builder

Feb 2026

trailos.app

Summary: Two live AI-native consumer SaaS products built and launched in 5 weeks. WildLog transforms raw trail notes into shareable trip reports. TripForge generates personalized adventure recommendations based on user preferences. GPT-4 and Claude serve as core product intelligence layers across both products.

- Performed market research, competitive analysis, and persona development to identify customer needs and product opportunities
- Defined product requirements, managed backlog, conducted customer discovery, and created acceptance criteria
- Led pricing, packaging, SEO-driven acquisition initiatives, and product iteration based on customer feedback and usage insights
- Partnered with AI-assisted development workflows to deliver customer-facing functionality from concept to production